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Going back to Venezuela proving to be difficult

Diplomatic hurdles, broken ties make return to home country hard

By Laura Turbay and Laura Rodríguez Presa
CHICAGO TRIBUNE

Drawn by the promise of a free flight back to her native Venezuela, Yessica Torres downloaded the U.S. Customs and Border Protection Home app, believing it would cover the plane tickets for Torres and her family.

But after almost a year of waiting for CBP to arrange their travel, Torres now feels stuck in a country that denied her family asylum and whose president has campaigned for their departure. She does not have a passport — the last Venezuelan consulate in the U.S. shuttered years ago — and the CBP Home app, which promised to fly her back as part of a program called “Project Homecoming,” has yet to follow through on its proclamation of cost-free travel and a monetary exit bonus.

“There shouldn’t be so much paperwork, so many permits to leave,” said Torres, 34, who is staying in a shared apartment in Chicago with her partner and two young children. “If that’s what they want — that we leave.”

Torres is one of countless Venezuelan immigrants who want to return to their home country, but have been unable to because of the broken diplomatic ties and bureaucratic hurdles between the two countries. Currently, there are no direct flights from the U.S. to Venezuela, and Venezuelan passports and other vital travel documents are nearly impossible to obtain after the countries broke off diplomatic relations with each other in 2019.

Some Venezuelans have found themselves in the position of making the same harrowing trek they endured to get to the U.S. — traveling across multiple countries, sometimes through dangerous territories — to return home.

“They left the country not looking for anything other than stability and peace,” said Illinois Venezuelan Alliance vice president of the board Jose Morales. Now, he said, they are returning back, in part, “because of the persecution by this government.”

To be sure, since the Trump administration’s ouster of then-President Nicolás Maduro in early January, an easier pathway could be on the horizon. Last month, the U.S. formally reopened its embassy in Caracas — though

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THE REGION: HOME TO STEEL MILLS, BEACHES AND ... THE CHICAGO BEARS?



‘It’s a true community’

By Robert McCoppin | CHICAGO TRIBUNE

David Kubacki has lived in both places where the Chicago Bears are considering building a new stadium — and he knows which he prefers.

Kubacki was born in Hammond, Indiana, but when he was a child, his family moved to Arlington Heights. After returning to attend Purdue University, he never left Indiana, raising his family in Hammond. His friends and family were there, and it made sense financially to stay in northwest Indiana, an area known as “the region.”

“If the wind blows in the wrong direction, you smell the refinery,” he conceded. “But we can be at the lakefront on our boat in five minutes. You can walk down the street at night. People wave. It’s a true community.”

If the Bears move to Indiana, they will become part of the region — a corner of the state that has much in common with both Chicago and Indiana, yet proudly protects its own identity.

“The region” can spark arguments among its own residents as to how the area is defined. Originally named for the Calumet region, bound by its rivers, it generally covers the northwest corner of the state, in Lake and Porter counties.

Many Chicagoans know the area only from driving through, and may think of it as the ruins of the Rust Belt, interrupted by the Indiana Dunes. The region rose from an industrial foundation, but like Chicago diversifying from its stockyard past, it now features a mix of quaint towns, luxury lakefront homes, booming suburbs and farmland.

Still, certain personal traits remain valued: a blue-collar work ethic, street smarts and a feeling of community.

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Above: Suzette and David Kubacki have been running the Lenten Friday fish fry at Hammond Mohawks AC&C in Hammond for 18 years. **E. JASON WAMBSGANS/CHICAGO TRIBUNE**



Developer Nick Serra on Tuesday steps onto the future balcony of a newly constructed third-floor unit in a building he’s redeveloping to add rental apartments in Chicago’s Uptown neighborhood. **BRIAN CASSELLA/TRIBUNE**

Pritzker’s housing proposals: More four-flats, looser rules

Plan would ease zoning restrictions that limit residential density

By Olivia Olander
CHICAGO TRIBUNE

Above the bay windows that run up the center of a two-story apartment building in Uptown, Nick Serra stands on what had been the roof but will soon be the balcony for a new third-floor unit he’s adding.

In many circumstances, the construction work would be a sure sign that another traditional Chicago apartment building was being gutted and converted into a single-family home that could fetch more than \$1 million.

Instead, the new top floor will be a four-bedroom apartment that,

along with other changes Serra is making, will turn the entire building into a six-unit development capable of housing a dozen people.

“Versus, you know, two people and their golden retriever,” Serra said, as he stood last week on the unfinished top floor.

Serra is part of a cohort of developers adding units to existing buildings rather than tearing them down or converting them to single-family homes — a practice many housing advocates say helps with affordability in high-demand neighborhoods. But finding lots zoned to allow the additional square footage and density he needs is difficult, particularly on the North Side, where he primarily works. Under current rules, he has managed roughly two

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US, Iran hold peace talks

The two countries continued face-to-face negotiations in Pakistan, days after a fragile, two-week ceasefire was announced. **Nation & World, Page B5**

When reports were works of art

Government reports tend to be pretty dry. But Northwestern shows a flashback to a time when they were a bit more scintillating. **Arts & Entertainment**

Bears’ priorities in the draft

With the draft less than two weeks away, a look at the team’s biggest area of need — and prospects who could be available. **Sports**

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